



PATH 20

Custom project setups

They want Claude Projects or Custom GPTs configured, not a lecture.

14 minute read · 3,186 words

Who this is for

Someone drowning in a blank project who will pay for a working one.

Time to first

3–10 days

Tools

First sale

One setup a stranger can use without you.

Cash window

\$97–\$297 per setup

Leave this alone

Claude Projects or Custom GPTs, a 5-minute walkthrough recording.

Selling access to a model you do not own.

What they actually buy

They buy instructions, files, and three starter chats that already work. You intake their actual job. You install it in an account they own. You test it. You record a five-minute walkthrough. You leave. They never need your login.

You are not reselling Claude. You are not reselling ChatGPT. You are selling configuration. Say that out loud so nobody is confused, including you. If your business requires them to keep using a project inside your account, you have built a hostage, not a product.

What “configured” means A blank project is a blinking cursor with extra steps. A configured one knows the job, the tone, the files it may use, and the three first prompts that produce something they recognize. The buyer should be able to open it on Thursday night and get a usable draft without writing a system prompt from scratch.

What it is not It is not a course on prompt engineering. It is not a second brain with forty folders they will never open. It is not you wrapping someone else’s model in a thin login screen and charging rent. Anthropic and OpenAI already sell the model. You sell the setup.

Who this is for — and who should skip it

This path fits if you have already made a project or a custom GPT for yourself that you actually reuse. People around you have said some version of “I never know what to put in the custom instructions.” You can sit in someone else’s job for an hour without needing to become their employee.

You can do this if - You can write instructions a tired person can read, not a wall of role-play. - You will hand the project over. Your name does not need to stay in the admin field. - You can record five minutes on a screen without turning it into a webinar.

Skip this path if Skip it if you planned to sell access to a model you do not own. Skip it if you want to keep their files in your account so they “have to stay.” Skip it if you will load confidential client files into a model against their policy because it is easier. Skip it if you have never finished a project for your own job — do that first, then sell the shape.

If you freeze at the idea of asking five people, this still works, but the first 72 hours will feel like the whole job. That is normal. The page and the five asks are the path.

The offer, named in one sentence

“I configure the project for your job. You own it. Walkthrough included. \$197.”

Jules uses that sentence. Keep it. The number can move inside \$97–\$297. The ownership cannot.

What is in - A 20-minute intake: the jobs, the files they are allowed to add, the tone. - Custom instructions they can read and edit. - Up to a small set of files they provide and approve. - Three starter threads that already return a decent first draft. - A five-minute walkthrough recording. - One tweak window of seven days. Tweak means instructions and starters, not a second job.

What is out Your Claude login. A monthly “I host this for you.” Training their whole staff. Building a forty-file knowledge base they will not maintain. Connecting ten tools. If they want pipes into email, that is path 19, quoted separately.

What done looks like

Done is a setup a stranger can use without you. They open their own project. They click starter one. They get a draft they could send after a human edit. They know how to add a file and how to tweak a line of instructions because the walkthrough showed both.

The hand-off test Log out. Have them log in. Watch them run starter two without you typing. If they cannot, the walkthrough failed or the starters are cute instead of useful. Fix it inside the tweak window.

Ownership, done The project lives in their account. You are not the owner. If they want you as an invited viewer for seven days, fine. On day eight you leave. Files they consider confidential follow their policy, not your curiosity.

Pricing

The cash window is \$97–\$297 per setup. Jules charges \$197. That is the default button.

How to pick the number - \$97 if you need the first case and the job is one you could configure in an hour. Once. - \$197 for a standard job: intake, instructions, three starters, five-minute walkthrough, one tweak window. Copy Jules. - \$297 if they have several file types, a tone that is actually picky, or two related jobs in one project (for example “listing draft” and “email follow-up”) still inside one setup.

Do not charge \$20. That is a prompt, not a configuration. Do not charge \$1,000 unless you are also doing automations and a staff workshop, which is a different quote with a different name.

Hosting is not a price If they ask you to keep it in your account and “just give them access,” the answer is no. That is selling access to a model you do not own, plus a liability you cannot explain to a lawyer. Configure theirs. Leave.

The first 72 hours

Day 1: a sample for a job you know Build a sample project as if you were the client. Pick a job you have done: weekly posts, listing copy, invoice reminders, a study plan. Write instructions in plain language. Add one sample file you are allowed to use. Create three starter chats that already work. Record a five-minute walkthrough: open, pick a starter, add a file, change one instruction line. Do not record forty minutes.

Day 2: the \$197 button One page. Sentence at the top. What they get. What they must provide (job, tone samples, files they are allowed to upload). What they own. Stripe or Stan at \$197. Buy it yourself from a second email so you know the confirmation works even if the “product” is a scheduled setup, not a zip.

Days 3–5: five asks Ask five people who complained about custom instructions. Direct messages, not a launch. “I configure the project for your job. You own it. Walkthrough included. \$197. If you want one, I’ll send the intake.” Do not explain five other services. Hand off so they never need your login.

The path, step by step

Pick the platform they already pay for. Claude Project or Custom GPT, not both, not a new app you invented.

Intake: the jobs (one primary), the files they are allowed to add, the tone in three samples they like, and any policy about data. Write it down. If they cannot name a job, sell them a cheaper pack instead.

Create the project in their account, or create it in yours only as a draft and copy the text over while they watch. They click the buttons. They own it.

Write instructions they can read. Role, inputs, output shape, what to ask if information is missing, what never to invent. Short. They should be able to edit a line without breaking the rest.

Add only the files they approved. Do not scrape their Drive. Do not upload a client list they whispered about.

Build three starter threads that already work: the three jobs they will actually open this week. Name the threads in human language.

Test with a real example they provided. If the output is fluff, cut the instructions, do not add a fourth file.

Record a five-minute walkthrough: where it lives, how to run a starter, how to add a file, how to tweak one instruction, who owns it.

Hand off. Confirm they can run it without you. Start the seven-day tweak window in writing. One tweak, if they ask. Not a redesign. Not a second project.

Leave their account. Delete any copies of their files that landed on your machine.

After the first stranger uses it without you, write the intake as a form so job two is faster. Do not add a membership around a setup you have done once.

A worked example: Jules at \$197

Jules keeps hearing the same sentence from independent bookkeepers: “I opened a Claude Project and then I just... stared at it.” Jules is not selling bookkeeping. Jules is selling a configured project for client follow-up emails.

The sample, built on Monday Jules makes a project titled “Follow-up emails — sample.” Instructions: you write collection and scheduling emails for a solo bookkeeper; you never invent a balance; you ask for the amount if it is missing; tone is plain, no “just circling back” stacks; max eight sentences. One sample file: a fake aged-receivables list with made-up names. Three starters: (1) 14-day reminder, (2) 30-day firmer note, (3) scheduling next month’s close. Jules records five minutes. The \$197 button goes on a page Tuesday.

The five asks Jules messages five bookkeepers who already complained. Two ignore. One says “I don’t pay for Claude.” Jules does not argue. One wants Jules to “just write the emails each week.” That is a service,

path 7, different number. One says yes: Mara, two days a week in her own books, already pays for Claude, hates the blank project.

Intake, Wednesday, twenty minutes Jobs: follow-up on unpaid invoices, and a short “what I need from you for month-end” note. Files Mara is allowed to add: her template phrases, not her real client spreadsheet. Policy: no client names in the project until Mara pastes them per chat. Tone: Mara forwards three emails she was proud of. Jules writes instructions from those, not from a persona Jules invented.

Install, in Mara’s account Screen share. Mara creates the project. Jules dictates, Mara pastes. Three starter chats Jules types while Mara watches, then Mara re-runs starter one on a fake invoice. It asks for the amount because Jules left it out on purpose. That is the quality check. Walkthrough recording is the same five minutes Jules already had, plus a 40-second ending: “this is yours, I’m not in the account.”

Mara pays \$197. Tweak window through the next Wednesday. She asks to soften starter two. Jules changes three lines. Jules deletes the fake sample file from Jules’s machine. Mara owns the project. Jules does not keep a copy “for the portfolio” with Mara’s phrases in it.

Copy you can actually send

The line I configure the project for your job. You own it. Walkthrough included.

The DM You said you never know what to put in the custom instructions. I’ll set up the project in your account for [job], with three starter chats that already work, and a five-minute walkthrough. \$197. You own it. I don’t keep a login.

The page headline A working Claude Project (or Custom GPT) for one job. Not a lecture. Not my account.

The intake ask Send: the job, three examples of a tone you like, and any files you are allowed to upload. Do not send confidential files you would not want in the model.

After hand-off It's in your account. Starters are named. Walkthrough is here: [link]. You have seven days for one tweak on instructions or starters. After that, a new job is a new setup.

What you do not write “Access my GPT, \$19/month.”
 “I’ll host your brain.” “Upload everything you have.”
 Those are the leave-this-alone line and a policy problem.

Week-by-week if you have a job

Week 1 Day 1: sample project for a job you know, plus the five-minute walkthrough. Day 2: page with a \$197 button. Days 3–5: five asks. Do not design a catalog of twelve industries. Hand off so they never need your login.

Week 2 Deliver the first paid setup. Keep the tweak window. Delete their files from your machine. Write the intake as a form. Do not start a “hosted GPT” idea because someone asked.

Week 3–4 Two more asks per week, or stop. If nobody buys, the job is too vague or you asked strangers who do not already pay for the model. Sell to people who already have the subscription. You are not also selling them Claude.

The quality bar

The bar is use-without-you. Pretty instructions that nobody runs are a brochure.

Instructions Readable. Editable. No 2,000-word role-play. A missing-info rule. A do-not-invent rule. Output shape in a few lines.

Starters Three, named for jobs, already producing a draft a human would edit, not a manifesto. If starter one needs a paragraph of extra prompting, you failed the configuration.

Files Only what they approved. Dated. Small. A second brain they will never open is a mistake, not a bonus.

Walkthrough Five minutes. If you need twelve, you built too much. Show ownership. Show the off-ramp: how they edit you out of the instructions later.

What to count

Per setup - Can they run a starter without you in the room? That is the first-sale definition. - Tweak requests that are actually a second job. Those mean intake was soft. - Time from intake to hand-off. Target: inside a week, often one sitting plus the recording.

After five setups How many still open the project two weeks later — ask once. If they never opened it, you overbuilt or you sold to someone who wanted a course. Average fee. If you are stuck at \$97 after five, press the \$197 button and live with fewer yeses.

Ignore how many knowledge files you uploaded. Volume is not quality. Jules's bookkeeper project used phrases, not a dump of five years of returns.

Objections you will hear — including your own

“They could watch a YouTube video.” They could. They have not. You are selling a configured job in their account in a week, not a lecture.

“Isn’t this just writing a prompt?” A prompt they have to paste every time is not a project. Instructions plus files plus three working threads is a small appliance. Price the appliance.

“They want it in my account so they don’t have to pay for Claude.” No. That is selling access to a model you do not own. They need their own subscription. You configure it. If they will not pay the model, they will not pay you fairly either.

“What about confidential files?” Follow their policy. When in doubt, do not upload. Paste per chat. Write that in the intake. Loading their client list into a project “to be helpful” is how you get a story you do not want.

“Can I productize one project and sell access to many buyers?” That is a skill pack (path 2), with generic files, not their confidential ones. Different product. Do not mix a custom setup with a shared GPT you rent out.

What this feeds — and what feeds it

What feeds a \$197 setup People who already pay for Claude or ChatGPT and stall on the blank project. Buyers of a skill pack who want it installed. Service clients who keep asking you to “just set up the GPT.” Your own sample and walkthrough.

What a setup feeds - Skill packs, if three clients needed the same shape. Generic version, no client files, sold as a file. - Automations, if they then want the project to draft from a form. New quote. Path 19. - A productized service, if they want you to run the job, not own the tool. - Not a hosted model business. That is the thing you leave alone.

Hand off. The best compliment is a week of silence because they are using it.

Mistakes that kill this path

Keeping the project in your account. Loading their confidential files into a model against their policy. Overbuilding a second brain they will never open. Those three still kill it.

The rest - Writing instructions they are afraid to edit. - Starters that only work if you are typing. - A 40-minute “training” instead of a five-minute walkthrough. - Selling access to Claude as if you were the vendor. - Bundling automations into the \$197 so you work a week for a setup price. - Keeping copies of their files “for examples.”

If you need their login after day eight, you did not hand off. Go back and finish.

Tools — only what you need

Claude Projects or Custom GPTs. One. The five-minute walkthrough: QuickTime, Loom, or your phone pointed at the screen, as long as they can hear you and see the clicks.

The rest A page with a \$197 button. An intake form: job, tone samples, files allowed, policy notes. Stripe or Stan. A calendar slot of 45 minutes if you do intake live, or an async form if they write clearly.

Do not add yet Do not build a native app. Do not resell API access. Do not stand up a team workspace they do not need. Configure the tool they already open.

Checklist

Sample project for a job you know, tested

Five-minute walkthrough recorded

\$197 button on a page, test-confirmed

Five asks to people who already pay for the model

Intake: job, tone, allowed files, data policy

Project created in their account

Instructions they can read and edit

Three named starter threads that already work

No confidential files they did not approve

They run a starter without you typing

Walkthrough delivered

Seven-day tweak window in writing

Your access removed

Their files deleted from your machine

You said out loud: you are not reselling the model

FAQ

Claude Project or Custom GPT? Whichever they already pay for and open. If they use both, pick the one for this job. Do not configure two for \$197.

What if they do not have a paid account? They need one. You do not sell them yours. Send the signup link. Schedule the setup after they can log in.

Can I do this over email only? Yes, if they write a clear intake. Live screen share is faster for hand-off. Jules uses twenty minutes live plus the recording.

How long should instructions be? Short enough they will edit them. Usually under a page. If you need four pages, you are writing a playbook (path 1) and calling it a project.

What goes in the three starters? The three jobs they will actually run this week. Not edge cases. Not “tell me about yourself.” Named, boring, useful.

Is \$197 too low? It is a setup, not a month of service. If they want weekly-run work, sell path 7. If the setup is truly two jobs and picky files, \$297.

What is the tweak window for? Instruction and starter fixes. Not “also build my content engine.” Write that down.

Can I show their project as a case study? Only with permission, and never with their files. Show your sample instead. Jules shows the fake receivables list.

Do I guarantee output quality forever? No. Models change. You guarantee a working configuration at hand-off and one tweak week. After that, they own the maintenance, or they buy another setup.

What if they ask me to stay as admin? No. Viewer for seven days if it helps them sleep. Then you leave. Ownership is the product.